

Christian king in England. It survives in the 12th-century *Textus Roffensis* (*The Rochester Book*). As it is written in old English rather than the customary Latin, it is also the first law code recorded in a Germanic language. It is based on German law and considers issues such as violent crime, rights and obligations, *wergeld* (compensation), and the status of the king.

See also: The Domesday Book 58–59 ■ Magna Carta 66–71

THE TANG CODE

624 CE

China's long tradition of recording laws reaches back to the Western Zhou dynasty (c. 1046–771 BCE). The Tang Code, with 502 articles and commentaries, is the earliest surviving complete legal code. It combines Confucian philosophy and the Legalist tradition of writing down laws, and consists of two parts: general rules and specific offenses. The Tang Code influenced future legal codes in China and across East Asia.

See also: Zhou dynasty China 24 ■ Confucianism, Daoism, and Legalism 26–29

THE BREHON LAW(S)

7th–17th century

The ancient Irish laws, known as Brehon law, or *Fénechas* (the law of the *Féni*, the free men of Ireland), were interpreted and preserved by wandering arbitrators called Brehons. Dating as far back as the Bronze Age but first written down in the 7th century CE, Brehon law was a hierarchical system, with harsher penalties imposed on those of lower rank. Its criminal

laws, however, discouraged violent and capital punishments, preferring fines and reparations. As England brought Ireland under its rule in the 1600s, Brehon law was banned and English common law enforced.

See also: Early legal codes 18–19 ■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63

THE LEX VISIGOTHORUM

c. 643 CE

Chindasuinth, ruler of the Kingdom of Visigoths (present-day Spain and southern France) introduced the Visigothic Code, revised in 654 CE by his son Recceswinth. The code marked the transition from Roman to Germanic law and covered the whole population for the first time; Romans living in the kingdom had earlier been subject to Roman law (*leges romanae*) and Visigoths to Germanic law (*leges barbarorum*).

See also: The Twelve Tables 30 ■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63

MEDIEVAL LAW SCHOOLS

11th–13th century

The rediscovery, around 1070, of Justinian's *Digest*, a compilation of Roman law lost to scholars for more than 500 years, encouraged the study of law at Europe's first university, established in Bologna in 1088. During the 1100s, Gratian, a Bolognese jurist, wrote *Decretum*, his textbook on canon law, which the university also began to teach. It became a specialized law school—the first since antiquity—inspiring other European institutions to follow its example. By the end of the 12th century, universities in Oxford, Paris, and Montpellier also taught law.

See also: Ulpian the Jurist 36–37 ■ Gratian's *Decretum* 60–63

THE GREAT LAW OF PEACE

12th century

In around the 12th century, the Iroquois Confederacy marked the coming together of five American Indian nations (later six) known as the Haudenosaunee. Together with fellow chief Hiawatha, their leader—the Great Peacemaker—formulated the Great Law of Peace, an oral constitution conveyed by *wampum* (shell-bead) symbols, that sets out a binding social and ethical code for the nations. The unity that the Great Law achieved impressed Founding Father Benjamin Franklin; its articles influenced the US Constitution he helped to frame, as the US Senate formally acknowledged in 1988.

See also: The Peace of Westphalia 94–95 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117

THE ASSIZE OF BREAD AND ALE ACT

1202

The first English law to regulate the sale of food was the Assize of Bread and Ale Act. To protect the public from rogue traders, the Act ensured the public paid a fair price for their ale and laid out the standard weight for a loaf of bread sold for a farthing.

See also: The *Lex Mercatoria* 74–77 ■ The Sherman Antitrust Act 170–173

GENGHIS KHAN'S YASSA

1206

Genghis Khan brought unity to the vast Mongol Empire in northeast Asia and imposed customary laws that only the ruling family could view and implement. No copies of